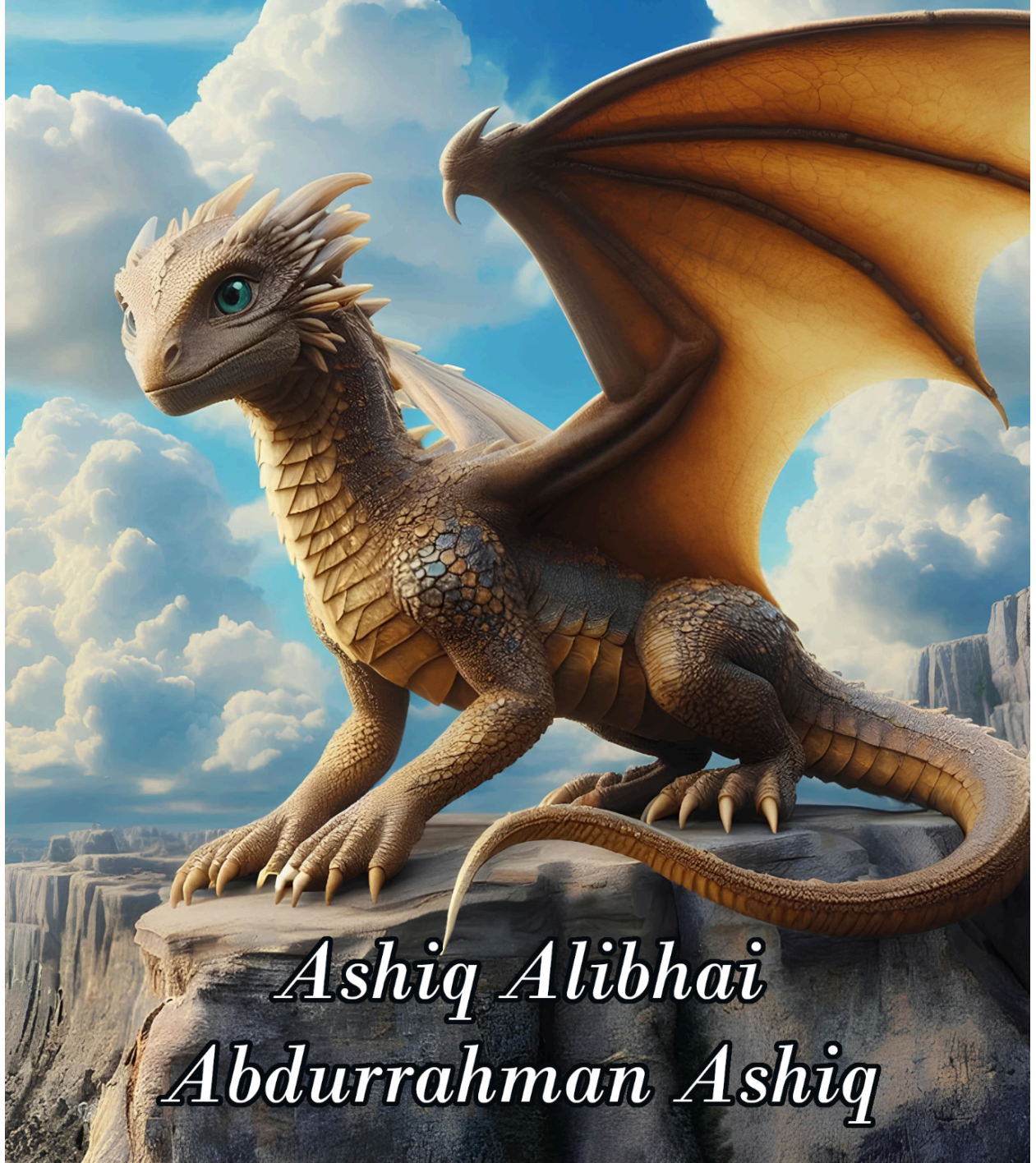


The Last Standing Dragon



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Prologue: Shadow of the Past

The wind howled through the blackened ruins, and carried the scent of ash and something colder—something final. Heavy storm clouds swirled overhead like smoke from a burning house as the rain came and went, leaving the blackened ground slick with mud but the destruction untouched.

She stood alone in the center of it all.

Her claws dug into the wet earth, her obsidian black scales dull beneath the dim light of the storm. She barely noticed the rainwater trickling down her snout as it mixed with the streaks of soot and dried blood that clung to her. The air was thick with silence, the kind that pressed down like a weight, the kind that only existed in places where no voices remained to break it.

They were all gone.

Her mother, whose voice once carried warmth even in anger, whose wings wrapped around her in the cold.

Her father, fierce and steady, his presence like the mountain itself—unshakable, unbreakable.

Her brother, her twin, the only one who truly understood her, who flew beside her every day since they had learned to fly, who had laughed at her terrible jokes and whispered secrets only for her ears.

Gone.

Distant fires crackled, the last of them devouring what remained of the great halls—the very place where they had once lived, ruled, and found safety.

She tried to save them.

She fought until her claws cracked, until her wings tore, until her breath came in ragged, burning gasps. She screamed for them, reached for them, but the storm and the smoke swallowed her voice, swallowed her whole.

And now, she was all that was left.

She had no name anymore. Not really.

Once, she had been a daughter, a sister, a queen.

Now, she was nothing but a shadow, a ghost of what once was.

Her tail flicked and sent droplets of water flying into the mud. Somewhere in the back of her mind, a voice whispered that she should leave this place. That there was nothing here for her now.

But she couldn't. Not yet.

Because beneath the charred remains of what had once been her home, beneath the shattered stones and broken wooden beams, something else remained. Something colder than the storm, heavier than the silence.

The truth.

She closed her eyes and let the memories wash over her.

It started with whispers.

Not the wind, not the rain, but something else. Whispers that slithered through the halls at night, coiled in the corners and slipped through the cracks.

Her father heard them first. She remembered the way he stood at the mouth of the cave one evening and stared at the sky as if searching for something just out of sight. When she asked what was wrong, he only shook his head.

"Something is coming," he said.

She hadn't believed him. Not at first.

Then the shadows changed.

At first, it was little things. The air in the great halls had felt heavier, the torches flickered when there was no wind. The echoes of their voices stretched too long, as if something unseen listened to them.

And then, the sickness came.

Her mother fell first. A deep, unnatural sleep, her breath shallow, her wings limp. Nothing could wake her. Not fire, not water, not even the healers who flew in from the distant mountains.

Then her father followed—not with sickness, but with fury. He flew out into the storm and roared his grief at the loss of his mate. He returned, and, within days, joined her in eternal silence.

Then her brother.

She had clung to him in those final hours, whispered to him, begged him to hold on. He smiled—weak, tired, fading.

"It's okay," he murmured. "The Creator's will is enough for us."

Then he was gone, and she was alone.

And that was when the last part of her shattered.

Now, standing in the ruins, she felt nothing.

No sorrow. No grief.

Only emptiness.

And then a voice.

Not her father's. Not her mother's. Not her brother's.

A voice like stone cracking, like ice shattering, like the wind in a graveyard.

"You have lost everything," it said.

She did not flinch. She did not turn.

"But you are not weak," the voice continued. Each word hung in the air like frost.

A shadow moved at the edge of her vision. Something vast, something ancient.

"I can give you power."

She bared her fangs, a growl rising in her throat. "Power?" she hissed.

"What use is power when everything I loved is gone?"

A low chuckle curled around her like smoke.

"Power is the only thing that remains when everything else is gone."

She stood there for a long time.

The storm raged on.

The ruins lay silent.

And deep within her chest, something cold and sharp took root.

When she finally spoke, her voice was quiet, but steady.

"Show me."

And the shadows obeyed.

Prologue: The Trap

The air smelled of fresh parchment and crushed herbs as Bilal's mother, Maryam, turned the delicate pages of the book in front of her. The words, written in elegant claw-scratched script, described rare plants with strange properties—some that healed, some that harmed, and some that carried ancient power within their roots. Each illustration appeared in careful detail: curled vines with bright veins, flowers that pulsed like living hearts, and roots that coiled into spirals beneath the earth. Some plants had warning symbols beside them, warning against using them the wrong way. Others contained claw-written scribbles beside them—notes, ideas, and hints at knowledge long lost to time.

The last page contained a map, recently inked and carefully detailed. Maryam knew the area well – dangerous storms often clouded that area, so dragons usually avoided it. Yet in the center of that area, a cave entrance, one she never visited before.

The book was a gift. A gift from the empress.

Maryam ran a talon over the inked map and narrowed her sharp green eyes. The empress insisted this book would help her research, that it contained knowledge lost to time. And yet... something about it unsettled her. The pages smelled faintly of something metallic, something old, as if the knowledge itself was somehow wrong. Still, curiosity won out. Perhaps she was thinking too much about it. The empress was smart, but she never behaved anything but kind toward Maryam. And if this knowledge could help their kind, wasn't it worth some risk?

She left at dawn, and soared high above the valleys and rivers, the book clutched tightly in her talons. The crisp morning carried the scent of pine and damp earth. Far below her, the earth rolled off into the distance: green hills, rocky heights, and wide rivers that shone like silver ribbons. The empress' words echoed in her mind:

“You should see it for yourself, Maryam. I found a place where nature holds secrets beyond imagination.”

That place lay far from home, an island of untouched wilderness where strange plants supposedly grew. If even half of what the book described held true, she had to see it.

Hours passed as she flew over the endless ocean. The waves below churned. Thank the Creator, no storm clouds in sight today. The sun glared off the water, and made her scales glisten and shine in shades of emerald green and yellow-gold.

Then, at last, it came into view—a dark, jagged island that rose from the sea like a broken fang. Cliffs jutted out at odd angles, their black stone worn smooth by time and wind. A thick, green jungle blanketed the land beyond, and hid whatever mysteries lay within. Dark storm clouds hovered over it.

The moment she crossed the shoreline, something shifted in the air.

A whispering wind curled around her horns. The trees below swayed without reason. The sky seemed dimmer here, and the clouds hung lower, heavier. The scent of salt filled her snout, and beneath it was something else—something old, something waiting. No insects hummed nearby. No birds soared above. It seemed as if the island itself held its breath.

But Maryam was no hatchling. Old stories didn't frighten her.

As she landed in a clearing, her talons pressed into damp earth. The jungle loomed around her, the air thick with the scent of moss, wet stone, and something faintly sweet—like honey, but richer. The ground felt softer here, as if the soil itself was different, lusher. Before her stood the plants described in the book—twisted vines with bright blue veins, with leaves that glistened as if dusted with stars. Flowers unfurled at her presence to reveal delicate, shiny petals that seemed to drink in the light. Some of them swayed toward her, though there was no wind. Maryam stepped closer, her

breath quickening. This discovery was beyond anything she had imagined. She itched to take some samples back with her to analyze.

She reached out a claw.

The vines moved.

At first, it was subtle—just a twitch, like the stirring of a sleeping hatchling. Then, before she could react, they lashed out. They coiled around her legs like living chains, and tightened with a force that made her bones groan in protest. She roared and jumped to take flight, but more vines snapped up, and wrapped her wings and tail.

She thrashed and ripped at the tendrils with her claws. She roared, and a burst of fire exploded from her mouth. The moment her flames touched the vines, they pulsed with eerie green light. The fire sputtered, then vanished as if eaten.

Magic. Ancient, powerful magic. She felt a sliver of fear slide into her heart.

The vines tightened again, and their unnatural strength pressed against her chest. She stood, forced to stoop, with her head pointed down at the ground. Her heartbeat thundered in her ears. This was no ordinary plant—it was something alive in ways it shouldn't be.

Then, she heard it.

The sound of wings.

Heavy. Slow. Purposeful.

A shadow passed over the clearing, and swallowed the dim sunlight. The wind stilled. Even the jungle seemed to hold its breath.

She strained her neck and head upward to see. From the darkness, a dragon stepped forward—taller than any she had ever seen. Obsidian scales gleamed like polished stone, and reflected the eerie light of the

cursed vines. The dragon's eyes, cold and merciless, watched her struggle. Some ancient power lay in that gaze. Maryam felt it press against her, an invisible weight that made her chest tighten.

Maryam froze, her breath sharp, as a thought came to mind.

She knew this evil dragon from somewhere.

The figure tilted her head, as if to examine a particularly interesting insect. Then, a slow smile curved her lips. "I wondered how long it would take you to find your way here."

Maryam bared her fangs. "You—you did this."

The dragon only smiled wider, and stepped closer. The ground trembled beneath her weight, as if the very earth feared her. She took her time. She knew Maryam was trapped.

"You always were too clever for your own good," she mused, her voice as smooth as flowing lava. "Too curious. Too much of a threat."

Maryam's heart pounded. This wasn't about the plants. This was a trap. A carefully laid snare. She had been played.

Did the empress know? Surely, she wouldn't betray her friendship to Maryam like this, and purposely send her into a trap.

The dragon took another step closer. "You should rest now," she said softly. "This island will be your home for a very, very long time."

The vines constricted, and pulled her down. The ground opened up under her.

Maryam let out one last roar, and poured every ounce of defiance into it. Maybe, just maybe, her children would hear it. She slashed and burned everything around her, but it wasn't enough.

Darkness swallowed her whole.

The preceding was an excerpt of the Last Standing Dragon. You can purchase the full book, from various vendors, here:

<https://ashiqalibhai.com/books/the-last-standing-dragon.html>